

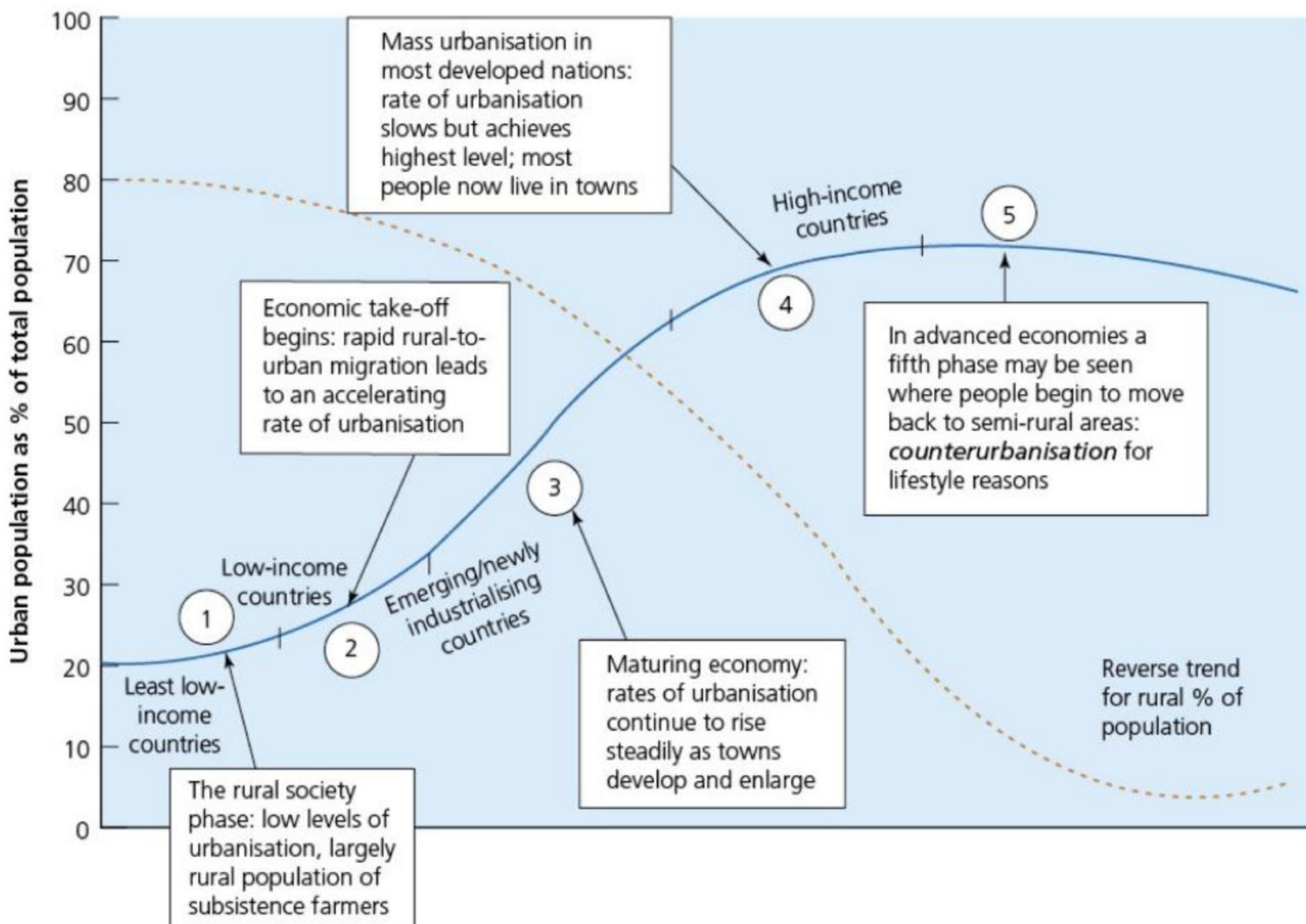
7.1 Where people live

This chapter will explain:

- ★ the reasons for variations in urbanisation
- ★ the causes of rapid urban growth in LICs.

Urbanisation is the process by which an increasing proportion of a country's population comes to live in towns and cities. It may include rural-to-urban migration and the reclassification of rural settlements as they are engulfed by expanding cities. It is one of the most significant geographical phenomena of the twentieth and twenty-first centuries. In contrast, **urban growth** refers to the physical growth (expansion) of the urban area and/or the growth in the number of people living in urban areas. Urban populations are those living in areas classified as urban. However, definitions vary by country. Most urban populations have a large size, specific urban characteristics such as a CBD, and economic activities that are mainly services and manufacturing and administrative functions.

Figure 7.1 shows that the **least low-income countries** (LLICs) have the lowest rate of urbanisation, and that levels of urbanisation generally increase as countries become more developed (Figure 7.2). However, for some HICs levels of urbanisation may decrease as some people prefer to live in smaller settlements and rural areas due to commuting/working from home and the perceived benefits of living in smaller settlements. This trend increased in some countries, including the UK, during the Covid-19 pandemic as larger settlements were seen to present more risk of the spread of the disease.



▲ **Figure 7.1** The process of urbanisation

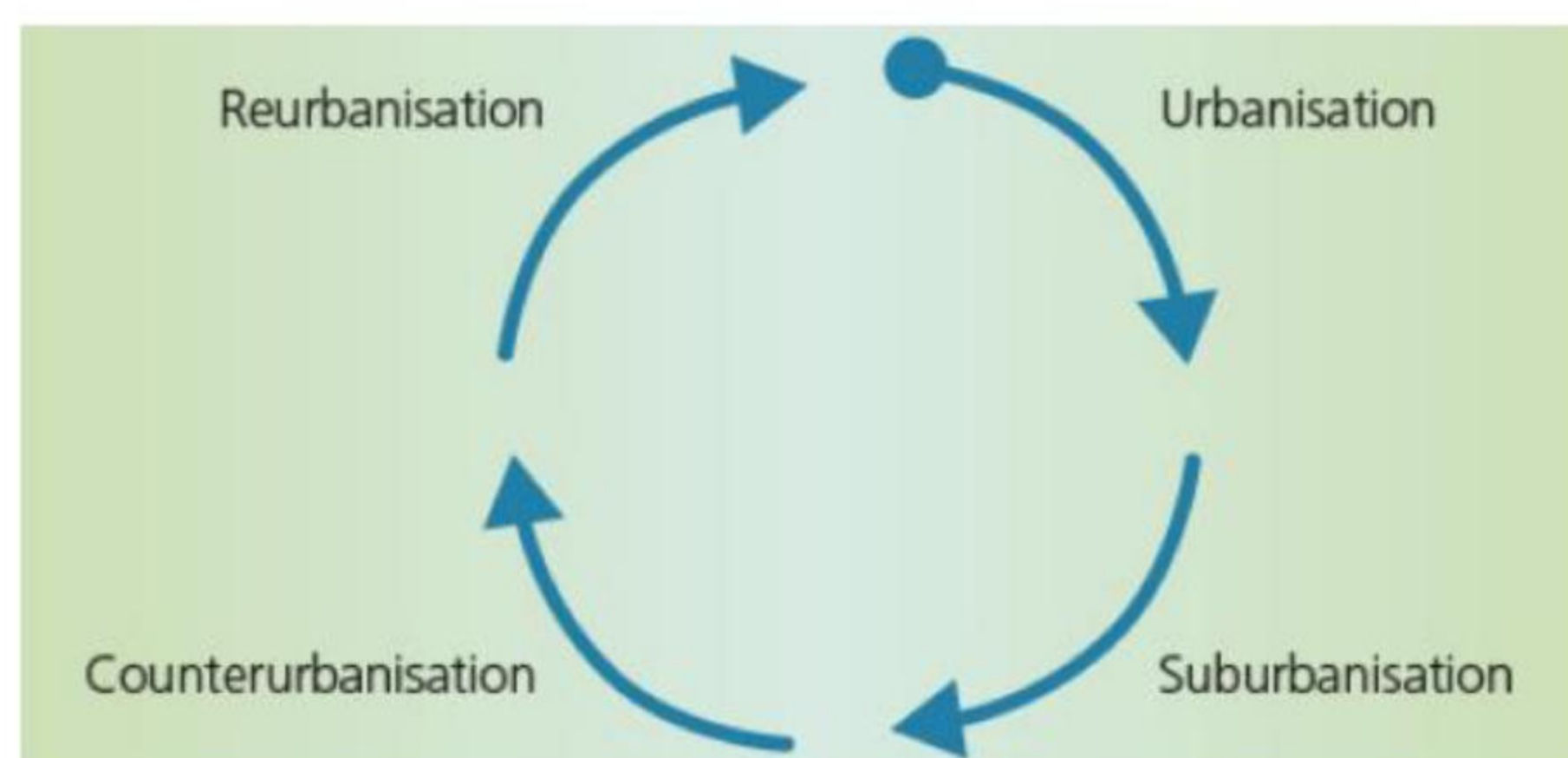


▲ **Figure 7.2** A high-density urban development, Seoul, South Korea

As with all models, [Figure 7.1](#) is a simplification. Not all countries follow this path, and there is an underlying assumption that urbanisation accompanies development (or vice versa), which is not necessarily the case, and that urbanisation is a good thing, which again is not necessarily the case.

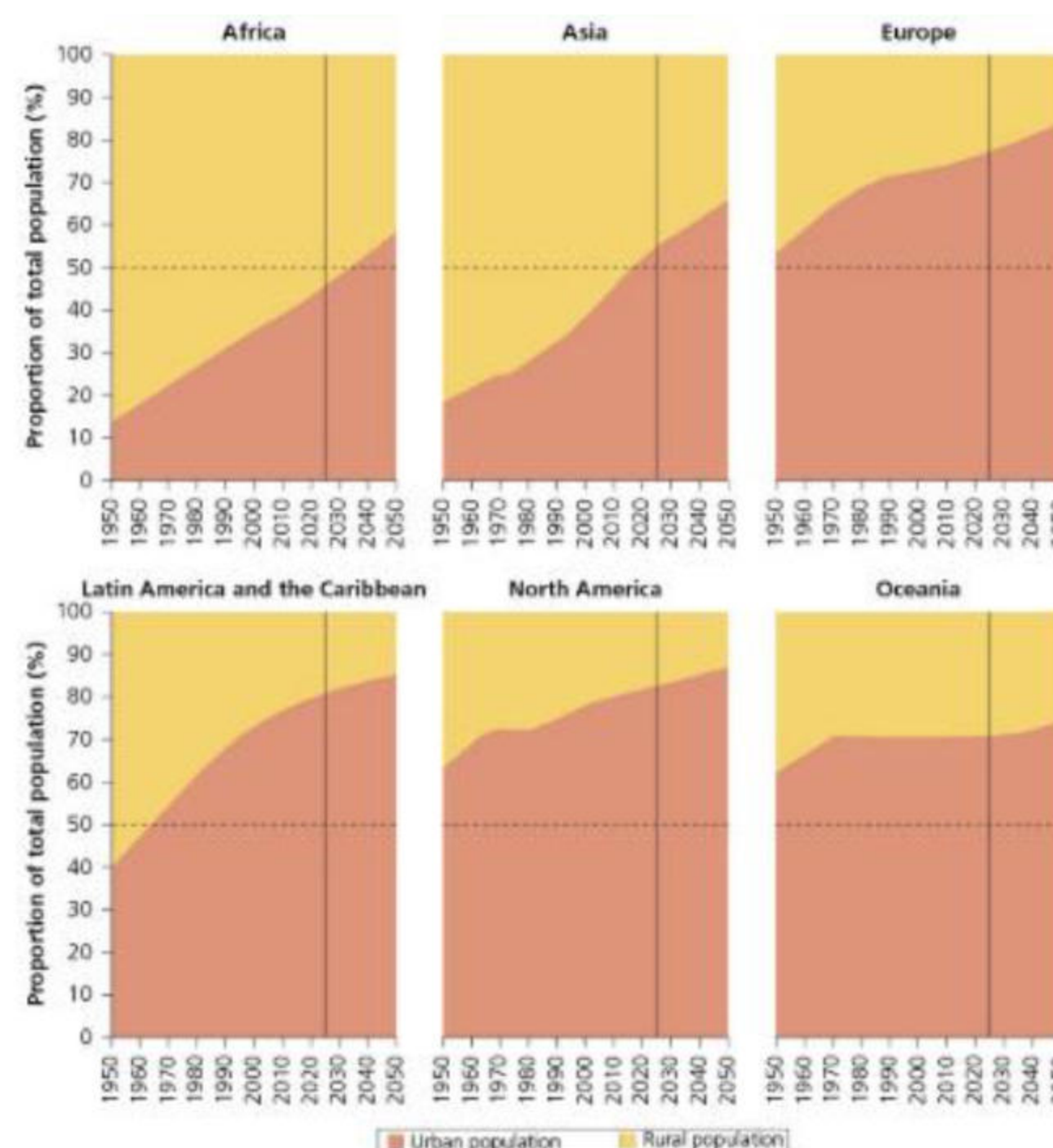
It is also possible to see a cycle of urbanisation ([Figure 7.3](#)). In many HICs, urbanisation dominated during the early twentieth century, followed by suburbanisation between the 1930s and 1970s. **Suburbanisation** is the outward growth of towns and cities at their edges to engulf surrounding villages and rural areas. This may result from the outmigration of population from the inner urban areas to the **suburbs** or from inward rural-to-urban movement.

From the 1970s, counterurbanisation became more widespread. **Counterurbanisation** is a process involving the movement of population from large urban areas to smaller urban areas and rural settlements. From the 1990s the regeneration of many inner areas resulted in **reurbanisation**.



▲ **Figure 7.3** The cycle of urbanisation

The proportion of people living in urban areas varies spatially (between places) and over time ([Figure 7.4](#)). Some regions are experiencing rapid urbanisation, whereas others are seeing rates of urbanisation slow down.



▲ **Figure 7.4** Changes in urban and rural populations by region, 1950–2050 (projected)

The reasons for variations in urbanisation

In the least low-income countries, rates of urbanisation are relatively low. Countries with very low levels of urbanisation include Malawi and Uganda (16 per cent), Papua New Guinea (13 per cent) and Burundi (12 per cent). These are largely agricultural economies with many subsistence farmers.

As countries begin to develop, there is rapid rural-to-urban migration as many people leave rural areas in search of better-paying jobs in urban areas. Countries at this stage include Kenya (with about 25 per cent of the population living in urban areas) and Afghanistan (about 27 per cent).

In maturing economies, the rate of urbanisation continues to increase quite rapidly at first as towns and cities enlarge. India's urban population increased from 25 per cent in 1980 to 36 per cent in 2023, whereas China's urban population increased from 20 per cent in 1980 to 64 per cent in 2023.

In the final stage (stage 5 in [Figure 7.1 on page 157](#)), large urban areas may experience a decline in population while smaller towns and rural areas experience an increase. For example, Japan's urban population peaked at 115 million in 2018 and fell to 114 million by 2021.

The causes of rapid urban growth in LICs

There are many reasons for rapid urbanisation, especially in LICs and emerging countries. These include:

- » the prospects of finding employment, better paid jobs and more secure jobs in urban areas (this is an economic pull factor)
- » better provision of education and health facilities in urban areas (social pull factor)
- » fewer economic opportunities in rural areas – farming and related work can be low paid, insecure and increasingly subject to climate extremes and natural hazards (economic and physical push factors)
- » poor access to clean water and sanitation, healthcare and education in rural areas (social push factors)
- » higher rates of natural increase (higher birth rates than death rates) among urban populations (urban populations are typically younger than rural populations)
- » some rural areas may experience environmental stress (such as drought, desertification, declining soil fertility) and so people move away to urban areas where they are less dependent on the physical environment
- » many urban areas, especially large urban areas, may be considered to be a 'melting pot' for different populations and people may feel that they can integrate in urban areas, irrespective of their nationality, culture and political views.

Urbanisation may increase rapidly due to the multiplier effect. For example, if a new activity such as an industrial development occurs, it can trigger further economic development nearby, especially in relation to services for the new industry and/or its workers. Employment multipliers are the number and type of new jobs created related to the new economic activity. Income multipliers refer to the value of the activities created.

Consequently, rural-to-urban migration may be large-scale, leading to rural depopulation and the growth of population in urban areas. The majority of those who migrate are young adults, especially those with skills and a good education.

Activities

- 1 Define the term 'urbanisation'.

- 2 Describe the cycle of urbanisation.
 - 3 Explain briefly the causes of rapid urban growth.
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▲ **Figure 7.5** There is a concentration of employment opportunities in central districts of large urban areas, as here in Pudong, Shanghai